CHAPTER 9 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The 15th Amendment

The vote — the most powerful tool in a democracy — extended to Black men, and the hard questions about who was still left out. 1870.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The vote — the most powerful tool in a democracy — extended to Black men, and the hard questions about who was still left out. 1870.

When a right is extended to some but not all, who decides where the line is drawn — and who is left on the other side of it?

The Ballot as a Shield

1870

Citizenship was not enough if you could not vote. The ballot was the tool freedpeople could use to protect their own rights — to elect officials who would defend them. In 1870 the Fifteenth Amendment declared that the right to vote could not be denied "on account of race, color, or previous condition of servitude."

For the first time, Black men across the nation had a constitutional right to vote. They used it immediately — and in huge numbers.

The First Vote

ALFRED R. WAUD, 1867

A line of Black men waits to cast their ballots — a craftsman, a well-dressed citizen, a soldier. The image shows a new electorate claiming its place in American democracy.

"The First Vote" — wood engraving by Alfred R. Waud, Harper's Weekly, 1867, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Line Drawn Short

WHO WAS LEFT OUT

But look closely at the amendment's words: it bars denying the vote by race — not by sex. Women of every race were still denied the vote. This split the old reform movement: some women's rights leaders felt betrayed that Black men were enfranchised before any women.

Frederick Douglass argued that for Black men, facing lynching and terror, the vote was a matter of life and death that could not wait. The disagreement was painful — and real.

The five military districts, 1867 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

What the Words Didn't Say

THE LOOPHOLE

There was a second problem hidden in the text. The amendment said states couldn't deny the vote because of race — but it didn't stop them from using other excuses.

Later, Southern states would exploit this: poll taxes, literacy tests, and grandfather clauses that technically never mentioned race but were designed to strip Black men of the ballot. The right won in 1870 would be quietly stolen back within a generation.

FREDERICK DOUGLASS, ON BLACK SUFFRAGE

Slavery is not abolished until the black man has the ballot.

Who Was In, Who Was Out

YOUR TURN

You'll examine the reach — and the limits — of the Fifteenth Amendment, and practice point of view on one of Reconstruction's hardest debates.